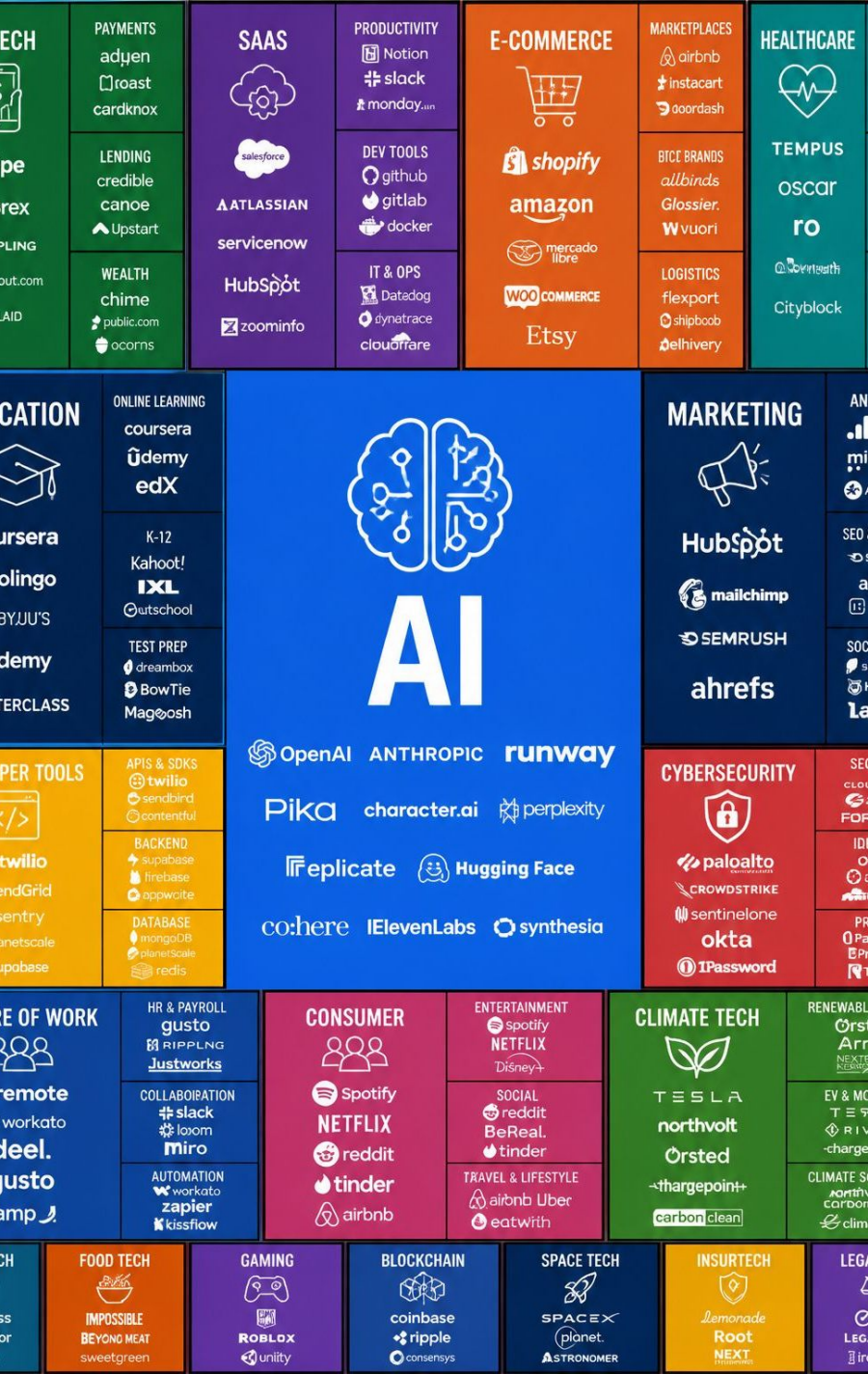


If I Had One Shot At Building A Startup...

Every founder starts with an idea. The hard part isn't building — it's making the right decisions before you build. This deck runs seven reality checks against a dataset of 1,000 digital businesses. Let the data be your mentor, not your hero.

If I were starting today, what would I do differently?





Reality Check #1

"I should build where everyone else is building."

Founder assumption

Popularity = safety.
Build where investors
and founders are
already active.

Category snapshot

AI – Startups: 197 ·
Median MRR: \$446

Education – Startups:
30 · Median MRR:
\$2,141

Marketing – Startups:
42 · Median MRR:
\$1,586

Productivity –
Startups: 49 · Median
MRR: \$42

Founder attention
and business
performance
are not
always
aligned.

What the data reveals

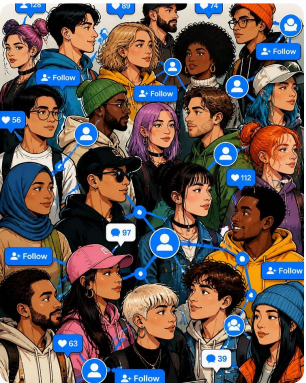
AI is the largest
category by count
(197). Education (30)
and Marketing (42)
show materially higher
median MRR.

Founder takeaway

Don't chase trends.
Chase underserved
customer problems.

Reality Check #2

"If people know me, they'll buy from me."



Followers → Awareness

Large followings increase visibility but show weak correlation with recurring revenue in the dataset.

Insight

Attention creates awareness. Customers create predictable revenue.



Subscribers → Revenue

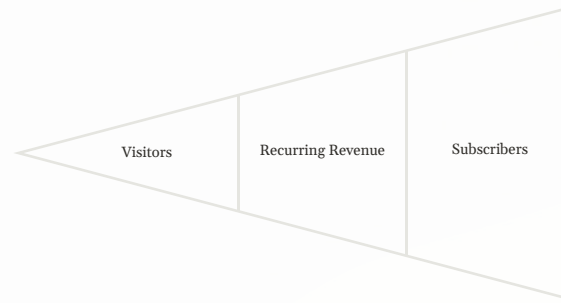
Subscribers are one of the strongest predictors of recurring revenue — intent beats attention.

Founder takeaway

Build trust before building reach.

Reality Check #3

"Growth comes from getting more traffic."



Supporting KPI

Average SaaS subscriber generates approximately **\$76 / month** (dataset average across recurring businesses).

What the data reveals

High traffic without conversion yields weak business outcomes; higher conversion rates consistently correlate with stronger MRR.

Insight

Traffic creates opportunity. Conversion creates business value.

Founder takeaway

Improve the customer journey before increasing marketing spend.

Reality Check #4

"Revenue alone makes a startup valuable."



Scatter plot shows a clear positive relationship between MRR and asking price — predictability drives valuation.

Customers

Recurring users and retention

MRR

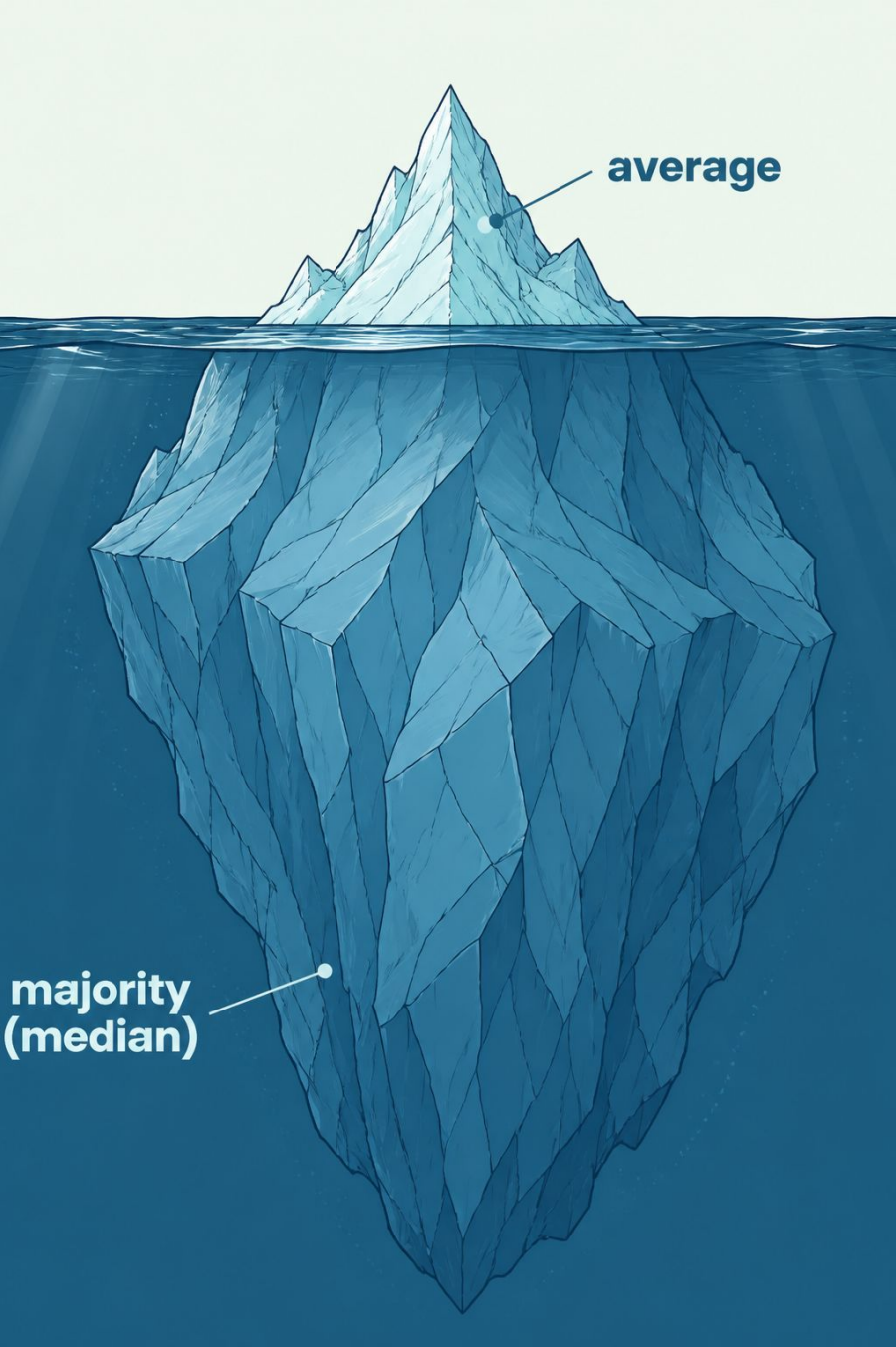
Predictable monthly revenue

Valuation

Higher, more defensible asking prices

Founder takeaway

Design businesses around predictable revenue, not one-time transactions.



Reality Check #5

"Everyone else is miles ahead of me."

What the data reveals

Outliers inflate averages. Most startups earn far less than headline figures suggest.

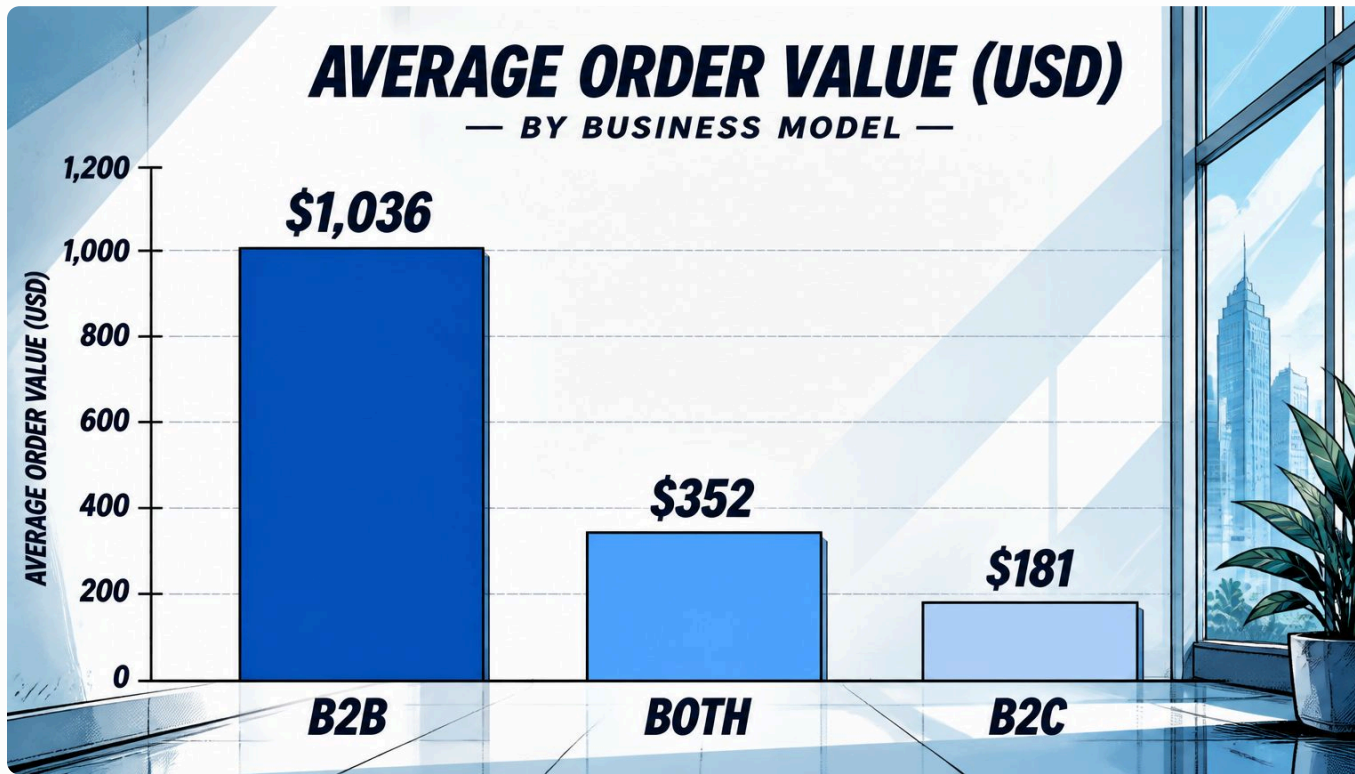
- ❑ The average startup is not representative of the typical startup.

Founder takeaway

Benchmark against businesses at your stage — not unicorns.

Reality Check #6

"Consumer startups are the obvious choice."



Insight

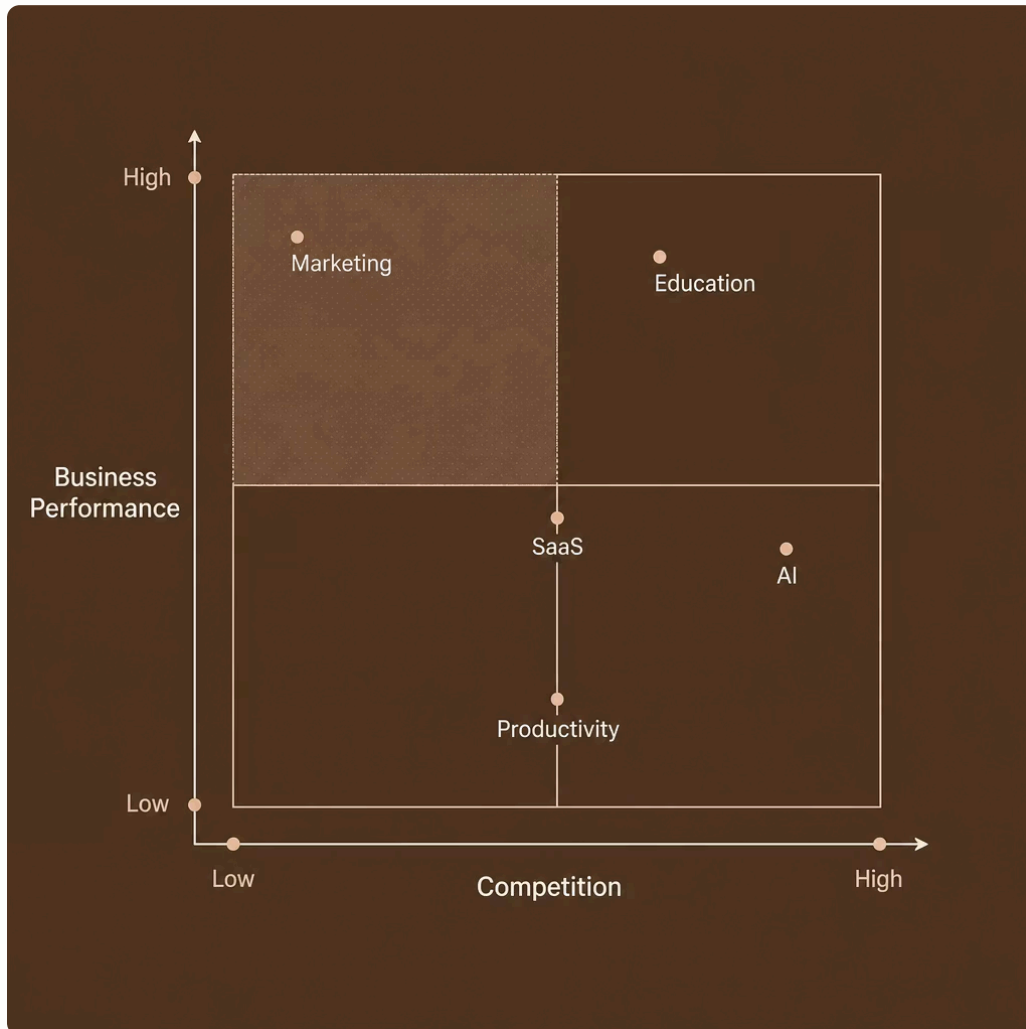
Consumer startups win attention;
enterprise startups win recurring revenue.

Founder takeaway

Don't overlook enterprise opportunities
simply because they receive less attention.

Reality Check #7

"The best opportunities are where everyone is looking."



What the data reveals

Strong opportunities often sit where customer demand is validated but competition is modest.

Insight

Competition is a feature, not a fate. Validate demand, then evaluate competitive density.

Founder takeaway

Compete for customer problems — not for crowded markets.

The Founder Dashboard



Monthly Recurring Revenue

Primary signal of business health and valuation momentum.



Active Subscribers

Leading indicator of future revenue stability.



Customer Retention

Retention compounds — small improvements multiply long-term value.



Revenue per Customer

Optimization lever with direct impact on MRR.



Customer Lifetime Value

Drives acquisition economics and strategy.



Conversion Rate

The multiplier between traffic and revenue.

Insight : The right metrics shape better decisions long before they shape results.

Founder takeaway : **Measure what compounds — not what flatters.**



One Dataset. One Different Founder.

Seven assumptions confronted. One consistent lesson: better decisions earlier beat luckier ideas later. Use data to mentor your strategy—then act decisively.

Mindset shift

From trend-chasing to problem-chasing.

Operating model

Design for predictability (subscriptions, retention).

Execution

Optimize conversion and LTV before scaling traffic.

"The best founders don't have better ideas. They make better decisions—and they make them earlier."